

a landmark work that provided a new classification system for the natural world. Beginning as an 11-page pamphlet, the *Systema Naturae* passed through 12 editions during Linnaeus's lifetime to become an extensive, multivolume text. In it, he grouped all living organisms according to their shared physical characteristics, then organized these groups into a hierarchy of increasing exclusiveness.

At the top of the hierarchy were the largest groups: three wide-reaching "kingdoms," which divided nature into animals, plants, and stones. From there, it extended down through different subdivisions as far as "species," the final group containing just one organism. This formalized structure—recognized today as domain, kingdom, phylum, class, order, genus, family, and species—enabled scientists to compare and identify millions of different organisms and rationalize the natural world.

Arguing that all living organisms reproduced sexually, Linnaeus grouped the plants on this basis. He also began a new phase in biological thought as he classified humans alongside other life forms and defined them as animals for the first time.

Labeling life

In several other seminal botanical texts that Linnaeus published, including *Genera Plantarum* and *Species Plantarum*, he completely overhauled and reorganized how different organisms were named. This was arguably his most significant contribution to the field of botany. Previous systems had included complex descriptive phrases,

as well as common names, which Linnaeus stripped back and streamlined. He provided each organism with a two-part Latin name (or binomial), which included the genus and the species—for example, *Homo* (genus) *sapiens* (species). This universal naming method—initially applied to plants, but later extended to animals in the 10th edition of *Systema Naturae*—was succinct, descriptive, and specific, and it established Latin as the official language of taxonomy.

Taxonomic legacy

Linnaeus's reorganization of the natural world marked a turning point in biological science. Although he devised it to reflect what he regarded as God's divine plan of creation, today it forms the foundation of modern taxonomy—the

In his quest to catalog the various species of the world, Linnaeus recorded 6,000 species of plants and 4,000 species of animals.

